

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Legal Operations and Compliance English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For legal operations staff, compliance managers, contract managers, policy owners, audit teams, investigation coordinators, privacy operations staff, and risk professionals.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Contract Intake and Workflow

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Policy Implementation and Controls

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

03 Compliance Audits and Evidence

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Internal Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Privacy Operations and Data Requests

Clarify missing information before responding.

06 Third-Party Risk and Due Diligence

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

07 Training, Attestations, and Culture

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

08 Governance, Reporting, and Risk Committees

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Contract Intake and Workflow

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A contract intake request says "urgent" but omits the agreement type, business owner, and required decision date.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: contract intake, template, approval path, triage.

Model response

Could you confirm the agreement type, business owner, and reason for the requested date? That will help the team route and prioritize the request using the actual business need.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Urgent does not identify the decision - The lesson's contract intake says urgent but omits agreement type, business owner, and required decision date; this is fictional workflow practice, not legal advice.
2. A renewal or a new agreement? - Separate fictional case: a requester labels a vendor document renewal, but the intake does not identify the existing agreement or whether the proposed scope changed.

3. A signature deadline or a requested review date? - Separate fictional case: an intake form lists Friday without explaining whether it is a signature deadline, a meeting date, or a preferred review date.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An attachment with no counterparty identified

A fictional contract request contains a blank template and the label urgent, but no counterparty name or business owner. No external deadline is supplied. Hold an intake clarification conversation rather than choosing an approval route by guesswork.

Role A: You are the intake coordinator. Ask for agreement purpose, counterparty, business owner, and the meaning of urgent.

Role B: You are the project requester. Identify the gaps and explain whom you must consult.

Possible opening: Could you clarify the agreement's purpose and counterparty before we determine how to route this template?

Success checks

- Clarify required identities and purpose specifically.
- Do not invent an owner, deadline, or approval path.
- Agree who will supply the missing intake context.

Add a complication: The requester wants to reuse another team's owner name because it makes the form look complete.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Policy Implementation and Controls

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A policy has been published, but nobody has identified who performs the related check or keeps the evidence.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: policy, control, monitoring, process owner.

Model response

Publishing the policy is one step. We also need to identify who performs the check, how often, and where its evidence is recorded so the process can operate consistently.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. A published policy is not an operating control - The lesson's policy is published, but the person performing the check and the person retaining evidence have not been identified.
2. A reminder is not evidence of a completed check - Separate fictional case: an approved internal process sends a reminder for a monthly access review; the reminder was sent, but no review result is recorded.

3. A control design differs from an operating result - Separate fictional case: a team has approved a design for checking supplier bank-detail changes, but has not tested or implemented it; no real transaction instructions are discussed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An exception log with no review owner

A fictional team records policy exceptions in a log, but nobody is assigned to review the entries. Logging is active; review and follow-up are unconfirmed. Explain how recording differs from monitoring and resolution.

Role A: You are the compliance coordinator. Explain what the log demonstrates and what it does not.

Role B: You are the process manager. Ask which ownership questions must be resolved before claiming the process operates fully.

Possible opening: The log records exceptions, but it doesn't establish that anyone reviews or acts on them.

Success checks

- Distinguish recording, review, and follow-up.
- Avoid asserting effectiveness without operating evidence.
- Agree who will clarify review ownership and evidence requirements.

Add a complication: A colleague says an automated log means the control is fully effective.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Compliance Audits and Evidence

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

An auditor requests records for a specific period. A team proposes sending a current screenshot with no date context.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: audit, evidence, retention, sample.

Model response

Could we provide evidence covering the requested period and identify its source? A current screenshot alone may not answer the historical question in the request.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. A - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Current screenshots cannot document an unspecified past state - The lesson's auditor requests records for a specific period; the team proposes a current screenshot with no date context.
2. A sample request needs identifiable records - Separate fictional case: an auditor requests the approvals for sample items A17 and A23; the process owner sends an undifferentiated folder of approvals.

3. A redacted record needs an explained limit - Separate fictional case: an audit evidence package contains redacted approval records; the reviewer cannot see approval dates, and disclosure permissions have not been reassessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A missing timestamp in an exported audit log

A fictional audit-log export omits timestamps because the selected export view excluded that column. The underlying timestamps may exist but have not been checked. Request a corrected or clarified export without assuming the source is complete.

Role A: You are the audit coordinator. Ask for the requested period, timestamps, and source context.

Role B: You are the system owner. Confirm the export-view limitation and check underlying availability before promising a replacement.

Possible opening: Could you check whether the underlying log contains timestamps and provide a period-specific export if available?

Success checks

- Distinguish an export omission from a confirmed source-data absence.
- Reject invented historical dates and request actual evidence.
- Agree the availability check and response timing.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests typing approximate dates into the exported rows.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Internal Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A hotline report contains an allegation and the reporter's interpretation. The intake note presents both as established facts.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: hotline, non-retaliation, confidentiality, evidence.

Model response

I'll distinguish the reported event from the reporter's interpretation and use neutral wording. The investigation process should establish findings; the intake note should not prejudge them.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. An allegation and an interpretation are not findings - The lesson's hotline intake presents the reporter's allegation and interpretation as established facts; no investigative conclusion is supplied.
2. A missing document is not proof of deliberate concealment - Separate fictional case: an internal review cannot locate a referenced approval email; no evidence explains why it is missing.

3. Two accounts agree on an event, not its motive - Separate fictional case: two internal interview accounts say a meeting was cancelled; only one account attributes the cancellation to retaliation, and no finding has been made.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An anonymous report with a named document

A fictional anonymous hotline report alleges that a training record was altered and names a specific file. The file has not been reviewed. Discuss the intake summary and appropriate routing without deciding whether alteration occurred.

Role A: You are the intake coordinator. Attribute the allegation and identify the unreviewed document reference.

Role B: You are the investigation lead. Ask what is known and what needs authorized review.

Possible opening: The report alleges an alteration and identifies a file, but we have not examined that file or established what happened.

Success checks

- Separate report content from verified evidence.
- Avoid inferring truth or falsity from anonymity alone.
- Agree restricted routing and the next authorized evidence review.

Add a complication: A colleague treats anonymity as proof that the allegation is false.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Privacy Operations and Data Requests

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A data request arrives with insufficient information to identify the requester or scope. Staff are unsure which workflow applies.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: data subject request, personal data, verification, exception.

Model response

Could we confirm the request type and required verification through the privacy process? Let's identify the relevant information without assuming access or disclosure is already authorized.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Clarify the request before selecting the workflow - The lesson's data request lacks sufficient requester identity and scope; the applicable workflow remains unclear.
2. A company contact requesting another person's data - Separate fictional case: a business customer contact requests records about a former employee; the requester's authority, purpose, and applicable process are unverified.

3. Delete my account or answer a privacy request? - Separate fictional case: a service user writes delete my account and everything; the intended scope and applicable deletion or privacy workflow have not been established.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A date range missing from a records request

A fictional requester asks for personal data related to support interactions but does not identify the relevant service or whether they intend all interactions. Identity verification status is also unknown. Discuss approved clarification without narrowing the request by assumption.

Role A: You are the privacy coordinator. Ask which service and intended scope need clarification through the established process.

Role B: You are the support intake lead. Preserve the original request and seek verification status from the authorized owner.

Possible opening: We need to clarify the service and intended scope without assuming the requester wants only recent interactions.

Success checks

- Avoid substituting a convenient scope for the requester's intent.
- Keep verification status explicit and use the approved process.
- Agree the responsible owner and precise clarification questions.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests selecting the last month because that is easiest to export.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Third-Party Risk and Due Diligence

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two vendors offer similar services. One handles more personal data and relies on additional subcontractors.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: third-party risk, due diligence, data processing, vendor questionnaire.

Model response

The service descriptions are similar, but the data handling differs. I'll make those differences visible in the due-diligence summary so the responsible team can assess the relevant risks and controls.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. A - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. C - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Similar services, different data-processing scope - The lesson's vendors provide similar services, but one processes more personal data and uses additional subcontractors.
2. A completed questionnaire versus supporting records - Separate fictional case: vendor A returns a complete questionnaire without attachments; vendor B returns fewer answers with supporting records. Overall assurance has not been assessed.

3. A narrow data pilot or the full integration - Separate fictional case: a vendor proposes a narrow pilot using synthetic records or a full integration using customer records; functionality and risk reviews for both are incomplete.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A vendor changes its subcontractor list

A fictional vendor's updated questionnaire names two subcontractors, while the earlier review covered one. Their roles and data access are not yet explained. Compare the old and proposed arrangement without assuming the added subcontractor is either harmless or disqualifying.

Role A: You are the vendor risk reviewer. Identify the change and ask for role and data-processing details.

Role B: You are the business owner. Explain the need to compare scope and seek authorized review before drawing a conclusion.

Possible opening: The updated list includes another subcontractor, but its role and access are not yet clear.

Success checks

- Compare the actual earlier and proposed scope.
- Keep the added party's role and risk unassessed rather than assumed.
- Agree a targeted information request and review route.

Add a complication: A colleague says the original vendor approval automatically covers every later arrangement.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Training, Attestations, and Culture

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

Training completion is 98%, but employees still ask how to apply the policy to common situations.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: attestation, role-based training, culture, reinforcement.

Model response

Completion shows attendance or participation, not necessarily practical understanding. Let's add role-specific scenarios and check whether people can identify the appropriate action in their work.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Completion does not demonstrate application - The lesson's training completion is 98%, but employees still ask how to apply the policy to common situations.
2. Acknowledging receipt is not certifying compliance - Separate fictional case: an internal attestation asks employees to acknowledge receiving a policy; a manager describes it as certification that every requirement has

been met.

3. A general course and a role-specific decision - Separate fictional case: purchasing staff completed a general conflicts course but ask how to route a supplier-related disclosure; no individual conflict determination is discussed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A quiz score mistaken for workplace behavior

A fictional team averaged 90% on a policy quiz. No workplace behavior has been observed, and the quiz's coverage of role-specific situations is unknown. Explain what the result supports and what needs further learning assessment.

Role A: You are the training lead. Distinguish quiz performance from demonstrated workplace application.

Role B: You are the department manager. Ask how role-based examples could clarify the remaining understanding questions.

Possible opening: The quiz score shows performance on those questions, not verified behavior in every workplace situation.

Success checks

- Limit the score claim to the assessed questions.
- Explain understanding and behavior as separate evidence questions.
- Agree a proportionate role-specific reinforcement check without inventing findings.

Add a complication: A manager wants to call the result proof of a fully compliant culture.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Governance, Reporting, and Risk Committees

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A risk committee tracker shows an action as complete because its plan was approved. Implementation evidence is still outstanding.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: governance, risk committee, risk acceptance, remediation.

Model response

The plan is approved; implementation is not yet verified. I'll report those stages separately and identify the evidence needed before the committee treats the action as complete.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. B - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. Plan approved, implementation evidence outstanding - The lesson's risk committee tracker marks an action complete because its plan was approved; implementation evidence remains outstanding.

2. Implementation complete, effectiveness testing pending - Separate fictional case: a remediation owner reports that a new check is implemented; the planned effectiveness test has not run and the closure criteria have not been reviewed in this conversation.

3. A missing status update is not an accepted risk - Separate fictional case: a committee action has no recent owner update; its risk acceptance field is blank, and no acceptance decision is recorded.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A deadline extension without a completion decision

A fictional risk committee approved a later target date for an action. Implementation and testing remain incomplete, and no risk acceptance decision is recorded. Give a status update that distinguishes the schedule change from the work and risk decisions.

Role A: You are the action owner. State the approved schedule change and the remaining work.

Role B: You are the committee secretary. Ask how the tracker should preserve incomplete implementation and testing.

Possible opening: The committee approved a later target date, but implementation and testing are still incomplete.

Success checks

- Distinguish the approved date change from completed remediation.
- Avoid inferring risk acceptance from the schedule decision.
- Agree a tracker update with completed and pending stages clearly separated.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to mark the action closed because the committee approved something about it.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Courts: glossary of legal terms

<https://www.uscourts.gov/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Legal Operations and Compliance English

Professional audience: legal operations staff, compliance managers, contract managers, policy owners, audit teams, investigation coordinators, privacy operations staff, and risk professionals

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Contract Intake and Workflow

Original fictional case: A contract intake request says "urgent" but omits the agreement type, business owner, and required decision date.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: contract intake: Collecting and routing the information needed to begin contract-related work. / template: A reusable document or structure used as a starting point for consistent work. / approval path: The sequence of people or steps needed to authorize a decision. / triage: Sorting issues by urgency, severity, risk, owner, and next action.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you confirm the agreement type, business owner, and reason for the requested date? That will help the team route and prioritize the request using the actual business need.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Legal Operations and Compliance English

Professional audience: legal operations staff, compliance managers, contract managers, policy owners, audit teams, investigation coordinators, privacy operations staff, and risk professionals

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Contract Intake and Workflow

Original fictional case: A contract intake request says "urgent" but omits the agreement type, business owner, and required decision date.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: contract intake: Collecting and routing the information needed to begin contract-related work. / template: A reusable document or structure used as a starting point for consistent work. / approval path: The sequence of people or steps needed to authorize a decision. / triage: Sorting issues by urgency, severity, risk, owner, and next action.

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Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you confirm the agreement type, business owner, and reason for the requested date? That will help the team route and prioritize the request using the actual business need.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level